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Pete Levin

Pete Levin was born in Boston on December 20, 1942. His diverse career has included performing on French horn or keyboards with artists ranging from Paul Simon to the Boston Symphony Orchestra. Pete has become well known in the music business as a creative composer and synthesist and his music is heard in numerous television and film scores.

Pete was interviewed in Danbury, Connecticut on November 20, 2001, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are in Danbury, Connecticut. I'm very pleased to have Pete Levin with me today for the Jazz Archive. And I was looking at your resume and so forth, and I'm wondering, if you have a business card, what does it say on it?

PL: A business card?

MR: Yes. How do you promote yourself?

PL: I do have, just my name and a line drawing of me and a phone number. That's it. That's all that's there.

MR: Because you do so many things. I'm wondering if you have a reputation now as one particular — in your electronic field or as a jazz player or arranger?

PL: I think probably not in one particular field, because I've gone into a lot of areas as a sideman and as a writer. It takes a long time — I've always been based out of New York. For a long time there was a large segment of people who knew me as a jazz player and never hired me for anything else, like a pop gig of some kind, although I've done a lot them with small names and with big names. But the two things never met somehow. And way back in my roots I'm a classically trained French horn player with a masters from Juilliard. Also I've got a strong background in classical, and I actually orchestrate the stuff I write for orchestra and large ensembles. But nobody in the jazz world is aware of that, so I've got a bunch of different people, depends on who you talk to.

MR: Yeah. I wonder if they'd be surprised to know that you have these other lives actually.

PL: I don't know if it's surprised or not, they just don't — well if somebody in the jazz world is saying well I need somebody who can write for strings, they wouldn't think to call me, even though I was next to them on the bandstand the night before.

MR: Right. Well you lived in Boston, grew up in Boston, and did you have a musical family? Because your brother is a musician also.

PL: My parents loved music pretty much. They're both fans. My dad had a nice singing voice and played the violin when he was a kid. But they weren't involved with music at all.

school system we went to in Brookline had a great music department and some really good teachers in the system, which, that's invaluable. That's so great because it inspires kids. If it's in you at all they'll just bring it out, they'll give you an opening, you go into the opening and that's it. And here we are. Where we went wrong, as musicians.

MR: You didn't pick a particularly easy instrument in the French horn.

PL: No. Although I have the theory that there's no such thing as an easy instrument. Some of them you get started on it easily. Piano obviously, you don't have to play in tune, you just hit buttons and sounds come out. Guitar — if you can tune it you can get some chords pretty easily, and you can strum, get a groove going, sing along with it, get an amp and play with a blues band. But there's a point eventually you have to cross of like when you're achieving something musical on any instrument and that's going to take practice and it's going to take development of skills and learning more about the style that you want to play in and the instrument that you're playing. And a whole lot of hours of practicing. There's a line you've got to cross and if you don't cross it you're always going to be — there'll always be so many people better than you are that it just won't work. So all instruments are hard I think. The French horn is kind of treacherous. I think I started it originally because a lot of people were telling me that it was an unusual instrument, it's hard to play, so if you play the French horn you'll always have work. You'll always be able to get into the band, because they need French horn players. I guess that was true to a certain extent. And I worked and I actually got good at it and then decided I wanted to do something else.

MR: Did the decision to become a professional musician, was it always obvious for you or was there kind of a turning point?

PL: It wasn't obvious. I went to Boston University, the School of Fine Applied Arts at the time, and there was a music school and their main focus was on music education, not on performance. So I got a degree then expected to teach because that's what I was being advised to do by guidance counselors. They said well you can study music but get the teaching degree so you have something to fall back on eventually. That's always been a sore spot for me. I think that's the worst reason for being a teacher that I can think of. Would you want somebody like that teaching your kids? Oh, I got this degree to make sure I'd be working.

MR: That's a good point.

PL: But I was advised a lot in school, and it made sense to me at the time so I got an education degree and finished. And I kind of sensed there was a gap in my performance experience. So I just said well let me — before I teach, let me go on to Juilliard, I'll just get another degree or whatever, or let me just play some more. And that put me into the

Gil Evans and discovered this whole new world, and finally realized I don't want to teach. So I got there eventually. But I didn't know from the beginning is the short answer. Sorry I took so long.

MR: I'm wondering what your musical tastes, about the time you went to Juilliard, what music were you passionate about at that time?

PL: Classical I think. I mean I listened to jazz and I was a Dave Brubeck fan at the time, who was — it was on the pop charts at the time. I listed to Dave and I was messing with piano a little bit and trying to play like Dave and copying all his stuff and Oscar Peterson. But mainly I was into classical. I still listen to it a lot. I'm still an opera fan. If I'm in the car it's usually tuned to a classical station. I think that's — I'm passionate about all kinds of music if it's being done well, but I think mostly classical.

MR: Your tastes seem to be pretty wide ranging. I'm curious how this Hammond organ thing came about.

PL: Oh I was in the Army in the late 60s, and I had been playing jazz piano in school just on the side. And I got into the Army and I was looking for ways to play. And there was a Hammond organ at the unit — well it was at the band rehearsal hall where I was stationed. And somebody else had been using it and he cranked it up for me once and showed me how it worked, and I says oh this is pretty nice. I started playing with R&B groups after that, playing organ. It's a great instrument. It's got this sound, it's like a human voice I think, just the aesthetics of it. It obviously isn't, it's electronic, but it just has that vibe to it. It's still my favorite keyboard instrument. It's the one that does the most for me here. It's a long term on it, I've owned a lot of keyboard instruments, I still do, now I just get them in modules, you know like the six foot racks of synths. But I went through a long period of my favorite bands were the ones where they would let me play organ. And now it's a resurgence. It's great. It's back. Now everybody wants you to do it. And my problem is moving my Hammond, which I can't lift it anymore.

MR: Right. Who are your favorite organists?

PL: Oh there's a lot of them. Jimmy Smith — oh I'm blanking. You can edit this right?

MR: Groove Holmes? Guys like that?

PL: Larry Young.

MR: Larry Young.

PL: Larry Young. Sometimes I get a lot of coffee and I'm racing and racing, and then my thoughts get left — Larry Young is just amazing. There was a big turnaround for me, I think somewhere in the 70s, because I'd been listening to Jimmy Smith, like everybody, and trying to emulate him, which of course you can't do but it's fun to try, there's just so much spirit in his playing. And I went to — I remember the concert but I don't remember

it was the original, Tony Williams Lifetime. But first — you're making me think of that stuff.

MR: Right. John McLaughlin.

PL: It was Tony Williams' Original Lifetime and he had discovered John McLaughlin and John was up there in a cardigan jacket and a tie. He looked like a dork. In fact, nobody knew who he was. And he was playing the most amazing stuff. And it was Tony and John and Larry Young. And Larry was playing a B3 but not through a Leslie, he had this amp, a big guitar amp, it was a Baldwin guitar amp, which I knew because I'd seen it in the music stores, it was a wacky looking thing that nobody was buying, it was I'm sure a big disaster for the company. But that's what he used. And he was just the exact opposite of what Jimmy was like. He used it to create textures — the organ that is, not the amp — he used the organ to create textures and different sounds. Technically he was a tremendous player but he just was not going the soul groove organ thing at all. And I walked out of there thinking man what have I been doing all these years — just wrong. And I started to track down his stuff. So that was a complete turnaround for me. I still listen to him a lot. It was really tragic that we lost him so soon because I can't imagine what he'd be doing now.

MR: Right. He was only what in his 30s or something?

PL: Something like that. But he was just doing such incredible stuff. The duos with Elvin Jones and, wow.

MR: How did you get into the arranging, the composing, the writing of themes for people and all that? How do you make those contacts?

PL: I've for the most part been a hired gun in those areas. I do — there's a lot of writing that I do that I have done that's for me direct with a client. The client can be a wide range of areas. Most often they've been through producers or production companies who know me, they've either used me as a musician or just know what I can do.

MR: But in the very beginning did you — you started writing tunes? How did you get to be known as someone who could do that?

PL: I don't remember.

MR: I mean you don't have to tell me specifically but is it just meeting the right people?

PL: I think so. It's probably the same process as just going into the area as a musician and becoming an active musician. You just get into the scene, hang out with people, meet them, play with them, and everybody learns what the other guy can do or can't do, does well or does not do well. Most of the music scene, it's probably why so many of us stay poor, a lot of it is done by word of mouth, a lot of agreements are made with a handshake, musicians are not good businessmen generally. But the New York — the music scene in

got interested in synthesizers in the early 70s and for some reason I had an affinity for that and nobody else could figure them out, which was great for me. So I was doing a lot of session work. When "Star Wars" came out I was just playing as a sideman on a lot of jingles, radio and TV commercials. And there was a period where I was just going from studio to studio all week with a small Moog synthesizer and my job would be to do laser shots or space ship fly bys — sheew — that was it. 56 dollars please. Thank you. With residuals.

MR: That's funny. Do you still get "Star Wars" residuals?

PL: Oh no. No, no.

MR: I just was curious.

PL: No this could be, it was just a style. It could be a toilet paper commercial but —

MR: Like a flushing sound or something?

PL: It was hip to have space noises going on because "Star Wars" was really big.

MR: Was this a Mini Moog?

PL: It was a Mini Moog, which I still have. Actually I've sold very few of my instruments. Some I gave away. Some — a lot of them are vintage and are still sitting in my garage. I'm not sure how much use they are. I can't think of what to do with them and I can't imagine how much value — they have value to some people I'm told.

MR: They do.

PL: I guess people buy — I don't know what they do with them when they buy them, they're really limited. They're fun to have.

MR: Was this the same Mini Moog that I guess you took on a Gil Evans gig?

PL: Um hum.

MR: Is that right? Now what prompted you to do that?

PL: My first stint with Gil Evans I was playing French horn, and actually got the gig, oh I've got a lot of stories, how much tape have you got? But that's one of my favorites, that's the greatest. That's one of the three or four greatest gigs I've ever had. I got it — Gil was doing a week at the Village Vanguard, and the horn player was coming in from New Jersey and he came all the way into town and he forgot his mouthpiece. And he was — I think he didn't want to do it anyways because there was a lot of work in the '70s. Everybody was really busy and his reaction was oh I don't need this anyway, and he just went home. And I knew a couple of guys in the band and I got this panic call, like, "Come down to the Vanguard, now." And I made it for the second set. And I was in the band for fifteen years.

MR: Oh, fantastic.

PL: Even back then, I don't remember how big the band was, probably fourteen or fifteen

on the jazz scene going way back: Howard Johnson, Johnny Coles, Jimmy Knepper I think was in the band at that point. I don't remember whether Dave Sanborn was playing — no that came a little bit later. Lenny White was the drummer at that point and Herb Bushler was playing bass.

MR: Lew Soloff?

PL: I think that was before Lew. It's really close. Joe Beck played guitar with them somewhere in that period on and off. Joe was having a lot of trouble with his eyes so sometimes he just didn't want to make club dates. But Billy Harper, Trevor Kohler, it goes on. But there were a lot of really strong soloists. And guys would stand up and take twenty choruses and it would be worth it. It was great. So I'm sitting there as a horn player and this went on for a while. And we'd play a head and then there would be twenty minutes of soloing. And there really wasn't a whole lot to do. And that had been going on for, I don't know, a year or so. And I was getting interested in synthesizers and was using them. And I talked to Gil about it. And he said, "Bring one to a gig, try some things." And I brought it with an amp, it gave me something to do, like in between ensemble sections. And Gil liked it and started writing little pieces for it and I got so I was playing the horn and Mini Moog over here. And then I started to bring a clavinet. Because the guitar players, sometimes he had one, sometimes not, or somebody wouldn't show up, so I said well I'll play some chords on the clavinet behind the soloist, and I got the Mini Moog. And eventually I was bringing so much keyboard stuff that it was hard for me to get back to the horn. John Clark joined the band at that point, so we kind of switched and I started playing second horn because John's great anyway. And I just started focusing on keyboard and then I stopped bringing the horn and that was it.

MR: Do you still play the horn?

PL: Very little. I have it, but it's not something you can not touch for six months and just pick up. For a little while I was playing in a brass quintet a few years ago, up here in Danbury, just with some friends. It was a very relaxed situation. Actually Alan Raph, who you interviewed, was in that, and a local trumpet player, Bucky Milan who I've known for years, he played with Urbie Green and Buddy Rich years ago and he's mainly an artist nowadays, paints beautifully. This was a very informal quintet, playing classical stuff. But nobody was playing their primary instrument. Alan wanted to play tuba, which he likes very much, and let's see the trombone player was actually a trumpet player but he loved baritone horn. So he was playing the trombone parts on baritone horn. And Bucky was really an artist, and the second trumpet player I think was a student and she was very serious and very much into it, but the rest of us were well let's have a couple of beers and play some brass music. And I was in a state where I was great for fifteen minutes and

be lobbying to — let's stop and have a beer, let's take a long break. Long answer to an easy question. So no, I don't play much. You can't, you really have to keep up with that.

MR: Was there any noise — no pun intended — from the musicians' union about the rise of synthesizers in the studio?

PL: Yeah there was a lot. The union, their focus has always been within — their boundaries are defined by things that they understand which traditionally has been Broadway shows, weddings, club dates. And they never really related well to the recording scene. They're actually better at it now. But by the time they caught up it was too late. I remember in the 70s there was an instrument called the mellotron, which was a keyboard instrument and it was a bear. It was like it was a real beast. And it had, each key was connected to a strip of recording tape, so you pressed the key and that tape, the recording tape would be pushed down on a capstan, or rotor, and the tape would play. And the noise would only last, I think it was seven or eight seconds or something. It was an actual recording of a violin or a flute. In reality the recordings first of all weren't very good. And also the tapes would start stretching almost immediately. So this thing didn't sound anything like string section. It had its own sound, which the Beatles used it a lot, but they used it in — and why is of course back to George Martin's skill as a producer — but they always used it in ways that they weren't trying to sound like a string section.

MR: It was just its own thing.

PL: They did the effect of strings doing some things. So it came and there was a big splash — it was very expensive instrument. And clearly it was not going to replace any string players because it was just a beast. It was always out of tune. It was the action — there was no action at all, it was impossible to play. To play a run — forget it. It was useless. But the union, after a while it took them like six months to a year, but suddenly they came out with this edict, mellotrons are illegal on session, because it's going to put string players out of work. They completely missed the point that everybody tried it said this thing's terrible. We're not going to use it. Nobody wanted to use it except as an effect. That's kind of where they've been at. Synthesizers, it took them a long time to understand them. They are really capable of a lot of unique sounds that couldn't be done by other instruments. But there is a certain amount of imitating of other instruments which was a sore spot with musicians. I think musicians were more angry than the union, which it took them years before they took any kind of a stance and then it didn't really matter.

MR: Well there have been circumstances where you could replace a string section with a synthesizer.

PL: Now yeah. The — I'm trying to remember when the first one hit, it was a device called a

the lore or the background or the genealogy of the synthesizer, which is an electronic instrument. It goes back to the stuff that Robert Moog built years ago, which was designed to make unique electronic sounds. The sampler, the only similarity is it's just controlled by a keyboard. It essentially records instruments, records them very well into computer memory, and you configure it to respond properly. You play a middle C on a keyboard, a recording of a trumpet or whatever, or a violin section playing middle C. It gets played back. In the right circumstances it's not even possible to tell the difference because it is a very good digital recording of the instrument. The effect of that has been overwhelming, I mean to the music industry I think. Or as far as — not the music industry, just to musicians as a group as far as musicians being replaced by other devices. So it's been an economic changeover. It's been going on really for I'd say close to twenty years. My first sampler, which was a very impractical device, it was three or four thousand dollars I think, but it only had eight voices, almost no memory, only worked on floppy disks, but it was the first affordable — at the time it was the thing to do and I got a lot of use out of it, and I had a huge library for it. I've had it hanging around for years. I just gave it away to Kenwood Dennard. Because he was using it as part of his electronic rig, still is. It was the same model and he had a lot of his own sounds on it. It was just triggering some unusual percussion sounds that he had made. And he was on a gig somewhere and it just went up in smoke. And I had a date coming up where I was playing with his band that he told me about, he didn't know what he was going to do. I says look I've got one that's hanging around here. That's what happens to my vintage instruments.

MR: Right. You could probably have a museum someday.

PL: Uh I don't know. My garage is a museum. I have to clean out my garage. But maybe that was a good start.

MR: Yeah. Well tell me about some of these — I don't know if these things have any particular significance or not — but some of the compositions you've done, some of the jobs. The United Nations Earth Summit theme in '92.

PL: That was nice.

MR: Sounds like a nice gig.

PL: Yeah. It was. Over the years I've always thought being a musician, any musician that you talk with this way on camera or just hit them in a bar, if they could start telling stories you'll have trouble getting out of the room. They'd go on forever. Any musician can do that. I've always thought that — first of all I'm lucky, very fortunate to be an active performing musician other than the fact that it's something that I love and people actually pay me money to do it, which never ceases to amaze me, and the phone usually rings,

they get to travel and you never work in the same place twice — well sometimes you do — but you work in so many different places. It's not like you're going to your office everyday. It's always different. So you get into a lot of unique situations and there are a lot of unique opportunities. And you never know what's going to happen when the phone rings. It could take you anywhere, to some country you've never been to before, to playing a style of music that you've never played before. Just all kinds of possibilities. That United Nations thing, I had underscored a documentary from somebody I met, a writer and producer and organizer, his name is Preni Gupti, he is Indian obviously. He's been involved in the United Nations for years and was doing documentaries about India. And he is a good documentary filmmaker. And I don't even remember how I met him, honestly. I think I was working for somebody else and then maybe I kind of met him, it's that kind of interface thing happened. But I met him and I did a couple of low budget TV documentaries for him. And he came back to me one day and said he was involved with the Earth Summit coming up for the UN And he thought it'd be nice, we should have some music. So he said, "Pete, why don't you write something?" I said well sure, okay. I didn't know what it was going to come to. I wrote a kind of anthemy piece and I got a friend involved, a sax player-singer named Pat Bianco that I've done pop gigs with and even a few weddings. And he helped with the lyrics and we put this thing together, and went into the studio and recorded it. And it was passed around the UN And then Preni called back and said, "Listen there's a big gathering in the General Assembly coming up, why don't you come and perform it?" I says, "Wait a minute, you're talking about THE General Summit? That one? The one with the —" Yeah it was — we did it actually three or four times. One of them they were dedicating a huge artwork that a Russian artist had just done. And so they opened the whole event with Pat and I sitting there, just piano and sax and vocal and we played it to a couple of thousand people, like dignitaries from all over the world, just sitting. Pat also shaves his head. A couple of bald guys sitting up there you know, just into it, doing what we do. Robert Rauschenberg I remember, he was sitting on the end of the dais there and he is known for taking a nip or two. And he was just kind of sitting there watching with this big grin on his face going like this. He was having a great time. And then Mario Cuomo got up and he started his speech by saying how great it was to come off the street where everything is hectic and just have some music to start with. It was great. I mean I never made a nickel from it, I think I would have been embarrassed if I did. And they went on to the big summit in Rio, which we were not involved in, but just the experience of playing in the General Assembly was pretty amazing.

MR: Yeah. And you go from something like that to Food Channel TV series. So when you get

PL: Yes. These days more suggestions than we probably like. That particular one, the Bobby Flay show, the original show, it was actually the director who came, his name is Wayne Page, a TV director that I've worked with, I've known him for years and done odds and ends projects for him. This was a case where he was doing "Hot Off the Grill" it was Bobby's first show. And they just wanted a theme. So he came to me and sat and watched over my shoulder while I created it. And that was it. It was fun to do. It was actually a low budget production. The food channel doesn't pay any residuals, so I didn't get too deep into it, because there's a lot of that on cable TV which is unfortunate.

MR: It's a kind of a one-shot.

PL: There are a lot of cable channels, very successful ones, who don't, they're not signatory to anything, the musicians' unions, actors unions, ASCAP, BMI, they just don't sign the contracts. And all this stuff has been taken for granted over to the big networks, they all do, they just don't do it. They realize they can get music and performances for nothing. Just don't agree to anything and you've got it. Another typical example is I've done "Saturday Night Live" a couple of times with the guest music artist. Most recently it was with Annie Lennox a few years ago when she was doing a promo tour and we did "Saturday Night Live."

MR: As a member of her band.

PL: Yeah. NBC re-ran it that summer as just part of their rerun segment, and everything was on union contract and we got paid for it, which — hey — we're doing this for a living. That's the concept. But Comedy Central reruns that show once a month or so and they don't pay residuals. That's more the norm I'm sorry to say.

MR: How come somebody can't do something about that?

PL: They try. It's not easy. It takes a big legal fight and ASCAP and BMI especially, they get to these things as they can but the whole music industry has changed so massively in the last ten, fifteen years. As technology changes the whole pattern of the way people are purchasing music changes. Right now we just saw the Napster stuff go down which was confusing just even for the people that are involved in it, and for the rest of us just watching. Was this good" Is it bad? I don't understand. I don't get it. And where did it come down. Even the way it came down was complicated with facing some realities. Okay they're losing this country, but it's just a website. They could just start the website up in France or something that doesn't subscribe to the same copyright laws. They could just do it from there. So people are writing music and hoping to get paid for it are saying what are we doing for a living? What's happening?

MR: Well let me ask you about that. As somebody who obviously writes a lot of music and records a lot, how do you feel about people taking your stuff for nothing?

PL: Well I don't like it obviously. It happens a lot in many ways. There's the concept of bootlegging for instance has been going on for years, which is somebody just makes an illegal copy or an illegal recording or something. "Illegal" being without permission. And they distribute it or sometimes sell it, sometimes just pass it around. It seems innocent on a one-shot basis. But one way or another, to some degree, it's costing some musician somewhere or a composer.

MR: I guess, yeah.

PL: A dollar, or two dollars if it gets widespread enough. It definitely has an impact. And I think people don't realize that it's the same concept of the way people copy software and pass it around. Computer software. It doesn't seem like a big — if you bought it and then make a copy for a friend or something, it doesn't really feel like stealing. The people that do it are not thieves, they're nice people. It's hard to see the impact that it's having on a whole industry when you do it. I had some help doing it but I contributed to it somewhere on my website there's a discography of stuff that I've done or stuff that I can remember doing. Not that mine is — there are people with much bigger discographies, but there's a lot of stuff on there. And as I traveled so many years with Gil Evans, especially in Europe, I started looking around to see what, okay, let's get a list of the albums that Pete is on. And he showed me the list. And he said, "Wait a minute, what is this? I don't have a copy of that. What is that?" And we looked and realized nobody had a copy of it and Gil didn't even know about it. And we recorded a lot in situations where the band didn't know we were being recorded. There was one great concert in the late 70s in Tokyo. It was I think still my favorite concert that I ever played with Gil Evans, for a lot of reasons — opening up a whole other story. Shortening it I had that particular day, it was in Tokyo, and I had just bought a brand new tape recorder which was my souvenir from Japan because they were cheaper there at the time. I don't think it matters anymore, but it was a kind of a cutting edge portable deck. And I bought it to the gig and borrowed a couple of microphones from the sound guys, and I said I'll just record the concert for the hell of it. And it was this amazing concert. And years later I took it back and transferred it to a multi-track tape, because there were some problems with it. For some reason I had no bass on it at all. And I actually brought Jeff Berlin in, the original bass player, into the studio. And Jeff is one of these — he's a very creative guy but he thinks like a machine. I mean if you play something once, he could, in ten years, play it note for note the same way. So I brought Jeff in and I had him replace all his bass parts, you know, playing along with it. And I kind of mastered it a little bit at a time. And then I put it together as a project. I gave Gil a copy of it, and he was thrilled because he had liked the concert too. And I talked to him about it, said you know I should get this to a record company and

record people to see if I could get some interest going. It was a little shaky. It was not great quality because it was a live recording and there were flaws, but it was nice, it was a really nice set. A few weeks later I was in Tower Records and just thumbing through some bins and I pull out a CD "Live in Tokyo." Hello? We never made any record like that. And I looked at it and I looked at the personnel and the pictures and the songs. They were the same. That was the concert. We have no idea who recorded it. I tried to track it down. It was an Italian record company, a Japanese production. Somebody probably taping off the board while we did it. And then they just issued it. Gil didn't know about it. Nobody got paid obviously. So much for my big production of a Gil Evans album.

MR: Stealing your thunder.

PL: So again I'm going on the long way, but it's eventually evolved into a publicly perceived perception or an attitude that any music that you see out there, it's okay to just take it. And again it's not being done by people who are inherently thieves or bad people, it's just kind of a prevailing attitude.

MR: Well the technology is there so why can't I use it? And it's a big temptation. I mean I know I kept telling my own teenage daughters I don't like this, I don't think you should be doing it. And then I'll look on their hard drive and see this song like, "Oh I'd love to have that. Why don't you burn me a copy of that." And I go wait a minute now I'm doing it too.

PL: It's the challenge of course that it's made the music industry re-think the way they're distributing music. The record companies, now they're hurting, they're feeling it now. They should have dealt with this much earlier. They're looking for ways to market music over the Internet. And there is no simple answer to it. They just went through a — I don't know a lot of the details about it — but they spent millions setting up this system of grouping together and selling music over the Internet. They overlooked one small detail, they hadn't made any deal with the publisher's associations. And the publisher's associations said wait a minute, you can't do that. We own the music, you don't. So they're still working on that. But they'll get there. But the whole system of downloading MP3 files over the Internet — some if it's done legally, some illegally, but some companies are finding ways to do it in ways that are equitable, which it takes some dealing and it means you're going to get stolen from sometimes. Like I have a re-issue of a Christmas record that I did ten years ago which now I have out on my own label, and Amazon has it, and I gave them an MP3 of one of the tracks that if you just click on it you can download it. And next to it there's a thing if you want you can pay a dollar for this or not, it's a choice of whoever downloads it. And obviously it's my choice to make it available. And it's not a sample, it's the whole track. The objective is simple, if you

different concept. You give somebody something and maybe they'll do it. And that's just one independent person trying to peddle his own music. Warner Brothers has to do it on a much bigger scale. They have to figure out how to market major artists without getting ripped off so badly that it's not worth doing it. If it's costing them two million dollars to produce a CD they can't afford to get ripped off too badly. So they've got to deal with it. It's a new world. And it started with the Mini Moog which is really something, when the technology was put in the hands of just the guy on the street, the guy in his living room. The Moog synthesizer was huge — I don't remember what it sold for, it was a lot of money like twenty-five thousand, twenty thousand, that was a lot of money in the 70s. But for two thousand I could carry one in a suitcase, and I did all over Europe. I could do that. The Yamaha — an incredible company — but they came out with a synthesizer, the DX-7 at around 1980, which got lost in the shuffle and it's a dinosaur now.

MR: I still play mine.

PL: But my feeling at the time was that it changed the industry. It changed the music industry. I played a prototype in Japan, right around then, in 1979, '80, and it was, I'd been using synthesizers a lot at that point. Analog synthesizers. And they just completely re-thought how this should be done with computer controlled frequency modulation processes, storing sounds in memory. Nobody had ever done that before. And the buttons that you push with multiple menu levels below. We take that all for granted now. I just looked at this thing, they let me use it for a concert, and they said we'll hook it up, here's your volume controller. And I'm looking at it, and I just turned to the guy and said, "I don't know how to work it."

MR: Where's the dials, right?

PL: Yeah there were no knobs, just buttons. And so the guy gave me a demonstration and I caught on to some of it, creating sounds. I did it eventually but I couldn't do it at the time so I'd call them up. It didn't sound like anything else. It didn't perform like anything else. It was great. And when it eventually got here it had this system, you could store sounds on a cartridge and pass them around, share them, steal them. That was the beginning. I got a couple of DX-7s early on in the 80s. And I got a lot of session calls so they paid for themselves quickly. After a year or so I started to realize that I wasn't getting some of those calls. A lot of the arrangers and producers that were calling me, "Bring your DX-7," the studios started to get them so I would just bring a cartridge of sounds and plug my own sounds into it. Then I started to realize I wasn't getting some of these calls because the arrangers that used to hire me had their own DX-7 and they would just bring it to the studio and play the part themselves. So it's really been going on I think for twenty years or so, or maybe a little less. And it occurred to me then that maybe this ride wouldn't go

MR: I should go back to just get your opinion on what made Gil Evans so unique as a musician and person.

PL: Oh that could take a whole other interview here. Well as an orchestrator his ideas, just the sounds and the textures that he envisioned were I think unique at the time when he first started doing it. And they made the sound of some bands that he was writing for, like Claude Thornhill and so forth, and when he applied that to specific projects, like some of his own ten, twelve piece groups, and then of course all the great stuff he did for Miles Davis, I mean just those sounds, the way he used instruments, the way he combined instruments, the voicings that he did were unique. I mean he had such a distinct style. But also that he really created textures. He wasn't just writing for — he never had a conventional big band. It was a sax section and he got three, four trumpets, some trombones, you've got a rhythm section, maybe add tuba, that was a big deal. He never wrote that way. And especially, he got into the 70s, he was — that was why he let me get away with all that stuff of bringing synthesizers into the Village Vanguard, where people were coming in hoping to hear "Sketches of Spain," and not getting it. But he was open to all that stuff. He thought the electronic sounds were fascinating. And he was into combining synthesizers beeps and barps with flutes and muted trumpets and French horns and tuba and an electric rhythm section. He was open to all those ideas and he heard them and he wrote for them very effectively. He had such a tremendous impact on anybody in jazz who writes music, just sketches arrangements, anybody who goes through that process of telling the guys what to play, what notes to play. Even if it wasn't a direct contact like I had, I was so fortunate to have for so many years. Everybody is influenced by that to some degree. That's one major influence or thing about Gil. Another thing that's always seemed very important to me is Gil was — the way Gil put ensembles together, whether in the studio or for his own live bands — they were based on, he just hired people that he liked. He liked the way they play and he would put them together in an ensemble, really without a whole lot of thought as to whether they would play particularly well together, that is whether the instruments would blend together. Because he was looking, first of all the textures, of getting the notes played, but also there was a spirit in the playing or an input from the players that he wanted to get, that was very meaningful to him. It's an individual player identity thing that — usually somebody is putting together a big band doesn't want that. I mean they want five saxes who really blend well together and are playing with the same head. It's just crossed my mind just a few days ago I went, there was a memorial service at St. Peter's in New York for Manny Albam. And the Village Vanguard Jazz Band, the Monday night band played there. And these guys have been playing together, this is the one that is the grandchild now of the

I mean they just all think and play and perform with the same — it's like one head. Sometimes somebody conducts, sometimes they don't even bother. They just do it and the sax section blends so well. It's just great. That's the way you do a big band. Gil, it just never occurred to him. There was one European tour we did, the band was a little bigger than usual but the sax section was Dave Sanborn, Arthur Blythe, Steve Lacy and Howard Johnson and George Adams. Now these, Howard playing baritone sax — he plays it but he's a tuba player and he plays with a lot of spirit on baritone but he doesn't blend with anything. Steve does what he does. Sanborn, who has changed the way the instrument is played but forget any concept of blending. It was okay. It was okay. It was great. Because any one of them that would stand up to take a solo he would tear the place apart. It was a great tour. But what an awful choice of five guys for a sax section. But that's what Gil did. He found Steve Lacy way, way back. Steve was just wandering around doing, I think he was starting to do the Thelonious Monk thing that he got into and expounded so well. And Gil just brought him into a recording session, some big record date, nobody knew who he was, and this guy who played weird stuff on soprano sax, a "weasel horn" Howard Johnson calls it. Steve was accepted into it, and some of his recordings like "Sketches of Spain" or "Porgy & Bess," it's great, with the digital reproductions of them they've gone back and dug out those masters and in some ways the LPs sound real classic. But they were victims of — they had to do a lot of compression to LPs back then so a lot of the quieter sounds were kind of squashed out of the picture. The CDs it's all there. It may not be the way you're used to hearing them, or the way you'd rather hear them, but you can hear everything. And every once in a while you'll hear like a second trombone player, he's just got a couple of notes and he'll just tie into it [scats] it'll come out. And this is not a guy that is not a great blender. I don't know who it would be but he was there because Gil liked the way he played. I came into the band, which I think is typical of Gil's attitude of first of all getting interesting players. If he liked the way they played, if he heard a blues element in their playing or something soulful, you're in the band. I'll write a part for you. He just liked me, which, I'm beyond honored. So there was this aspect also of where he would find young players or developing players and just put them in the band and bring them along and give them opportunities that were invaluable, I mean just invaluable. I couldn't begin to assess, even at this point, what I got out of being in that band for that long, the tremendous help that it was to me, not just career, I mean it changed the way I think about music, about the way I play, the way I write, everything. There still is, what twelve, thirteen years since we've lost Gil, I still never sit down at an instrument with a piece of score paper without having some of Gil's influence to show up in it. Oh what else. People — Hiram Bullock came into the band at

lot of Jimi Hendrix in Hiram's playing. Not the exact notes or the riffs just the spirit that Hiram plays with. And Hiram does what he does and a lot of people didn't like it. A lot of people didn't like it. Audience. The band — we had a great time. And Hiram I remember him saying man, I don't know what I'm doing in this band but I'm here. And Gil wrote for him, he featured him, he liked the way he played. And Delmar Brown was another one. Delmar is a wonderful player. He's not real good at playing other people's music. Gil loved the way he played. You're in the band.

MR: Did people in the band ever go "what is he doing?" Well I mean you just basically said it, talking about the sax players, but did you ever say like oh my God, now he's got this guy in here.

PL: Well Gil was an institution, I mean before I met him. He led the band, his concept was he wants to see where the music can go. That is the whole thing, that sums it up. Some nights the band was pretty loose and some nights it was great. If we had a bad night everybody knew it, it happened. When the band was really on, the impact was incredible. It could happen for a lot of reasons, but sometimes just playing the arrangements themselves sometimes a couple of guys in the band would really be up and would have a great night and would catch an audience at the right time and it was like being at a pop concert as far as audience reaction was concerned, which obviously is not the bottom line criteria for doing jazz. But the band had a tremendous impact and Gil did very little to actually direct it. He never told anybody what to do, what to play. If he didn't like the way you played you just wouldn't be there, you'd get fired or laid off or something. And he very seldom — it didn't happen very often, he wouldn't even explain why he was doing it — he would just well, "I've got to change this," and it would change. But he never told anybody what to play. Well once — great story — I've got time to do this before I forget. He didn't call the tunes. He would just sit at the piano and just kind of wait between tunes and then he would just start playing something and would leave it to us to figure out what tune it was he was playing. And we would eventually all find it and the rhythm section would find it and get something going. And then he might or might not give us just a cue, okay, start playing the chart. More often than not we'd get into the groove of the chart and somebody would stand up and solo and there'd be a couple of solos and then maybe then we'd play the chart. And this could go on for a set that started at 11:30 at night at Sweet Basil's and end at two in the morning, and Gil would stand up and look around and say, "Did we play an hour yet?" And that's it. That's the way the band was. It was wonderful. But the key was having Gil there. Because of who he was he was so universally respected, I don't know if I could describe what a tangible that thing was at the time, but you couldn't — there's just no way you could be on his bandstand

played. If you played something jive you'd hear about it the next week. "Don't do that anymore. Don't do that." But it was typical. We'd be playing some late night set at Sweet Basil's on a Monday night and someone like Mick Jagger would be sitting in a dark corner with glasses on trying to be as inconspicuous as possible, just kind of listening to the band. Wow. And just a bunch of New York guys playing jazz and taking far too long solos and a leader that didn't want to lead. But it was just the respect, it was unspoken but it was felt for Gil, it was an incredible thing, largely because of what he had done in the past, but also he led the Gil Evans Orchestra in that stage and then went on to the 70s and most of the 80s. So it wasn't all based on "Sketches of Spain" and like a couple of good charts and a hit record. It was a lot more than that. I'll be quick. The one story that I was thinking of, we were somewhere in Europe, we were in Paris. And I can't remember why but we had lost the drummer. The drummer had to go home. So we came into Paris, we were playing at a club, it was a big club, it was in a basement, I think it used to be a subway station or something, I don't remember the name of it, it was a long time ago. Although we came into town and we had no drummer. Steve Lacy I think played the concert. I don't know if he was on the tour or not but Steve lived in Paris. So he's got a young drummer that he's using in his own band and why don't we use this guy. He said fine, sounds good. It was a young guy, good player. He was really nervous. I mean he was just totally intimidated by the situation, which can happen. The club was kind of this basement thing, it was all stone with archways over our head. There was no seating, everybody was just seated on the floor all around us. So we were in the bandstand, like there were people right up to the edge of us sitting cross-legged. And we played a few tunes and Gil typically wouldn't call the tunes between, he would just sit at the piano and think for a while or he'd stand up and rock back and forth and sit down and start playing something. So we were in one of those minute gaps between tunes, like what's going to happen. And Gil walked over to this young drummer, who had been trying so hard, trying to read the book, and it just wasn't working. And we all kind of knew that it wasn't that he couldn't play, he could play, but it just was not working. Gil just walked over to him and looked him in the face and said, "Quit playing what you think I want you to play." That's it. And he grabbed the book. Took the drum book, walked back to the piano, and he called "Gone" the uptempo of the thing from "Porgy & Bess," which is a big drum feature. And it's all asymmetrical. It's not like the band plays eight bars, the drummer plays eight bars, nothing like that. It's totally asymmetrical. There's no way you could play it without the chart. But it's like okay we're going to play, we're leaving space for the drums, do what you do. Just do it. It didn't work but it was — he tried. But that line, "Quit playing what you think I want you to play," that could have applied to any one of

MR: Wow. Good story.

PL: Anyway that was Gil. How long did I spend answering that question? I'm sorry.

MR: Well he deserves it, right?

PL: He was absolutely incredible. It was like going to music school but it was way beyond that. He was like a mentor and a teacher to so many people. And a lot of people went through that band in the 70s and 80s and I'm sure they would tell you the same thing that their playing and their musical thinking is affected by the time they spent with Gil. And anybody that they've worked with, I mean it just kind of spreads. I mentioned the memorial concert for Manny Albam. There was one for Gil at St. Peter's in the 80s after he had passed. And the place was packed like beyond its capability to handle people. It wasn't just standing room only, it was standing room like this in the balconies and the entrances, and people had flown over from England and Europe just to go to that and then went right back. They were just kind of looking around the room and realized how many people he had affected. And those were just the people who could get there that day.

MR: Of the pop people that you've worked with, do any of them stand out as particularly memorable? Enjoyable?

PL: Oh sure. They're all enjoyable — Paul Simon is one of my favorite composers. That says a lot. Just to be on stage with him and doing his music is great. Annie Lennox who I did more recently, Annie is a wonderful singer and I like her music a lot. Performing it is a restricted situation. Annie works out carefully what it is she wants to do and she is very good at that so the performance — here's the record—

MR: Re-creating.

PL: We're duplicating that and we're going to re-create it live and don't stray at all. That's it. I'm not being critical of that, I mean it's a very viable situation, certainly as a performance it makes a great performance. I always thought Annie had it in her, I get a very bluesy feeling from her singing. I think that's inside of her. I think she could probably stretch out and improvise a lot and definitely hold her own. I mean she's a tremendous talent and she's got a great voice. But she feels it's important to work out how she's going to do something and then do that, and she doesn't want to stray from it so of course it's important for her to have — you don't want a bunch of jazz guys in back — let's try this, I've got a great groove for this. No. That doesn't work.

MR: Almost more like an actress would. More like scripted. Want to stick to the script.

PL: A little bit. Yeah that is it. If we could qualify it and make it a stage actress as opposed to film. Because things can change. I mean it's never absolutely pat in the same way, otherwise why go to a concert, you'd better listen to the record. But to work out a show and know what's going to happen, just work out the strongest way of putting the music

everybody knows is going to be different every time so it's okay. I think somebody like Annie, where the fans really want to hear the song the way they just heard it on the record. Some of them would like it if it strays a little bit, a lot wouldn't. Peter Gabriel was also a tremendous artist and a very creative thinker. I always respected him for going out on live tours, big tours supporting major albums, and he would just go with his band. And they would kind of do the same arrangements but they didn't sound exactly the same. Yet he was confident enough to allow that leeway, which I think takes a lot. It's a lot of pressure on you, playing to fifteen thousand people, that's a lot of pressure, and you're judged by everything, every time you open your mouth.

MR: With all the things you do, if you could take a year off — not really off — and do the thing you like the best, can you nail that down? What do you really like to do the best?

PL: It changes from year to year, decade to decade. It was in the end of the 80s I'd never signed a personal record deal before, and I did, I signed with Grammavision. And I had it in mind that I wanted to put a performing unit together and start writing some music and start fairly conventional and after five or six years try to break some new ground. I didn't know if it was possible or if it was possible for me. But it was a scheme anyway. The Grammavision had problems and it didn't work out. They went under after a couple of years. I think during that period it was getting harder to get a live group out there and find work. It was expensive. The tours that I did, I had to finance them. They were to promote a record but it was difficult to do. And in fact I'd been in the music scene, in the jazz scene for a long time, for many years, but when you turn the corner and you become a band leader, a solo artist, it's kind of like starting from scratch. You know any PR that was done, it was somebody else's PR. It's easy to say hey I want to go to Japan, but like how many write-ups have you got in the press in Japan, not Gil Evans or the people you're working for. So you're kind of starting from — maybe not from square one but square two anyway. And you have to work on it. And I was getting confident through that period so it was something I felt I wanted to do. And I did it for a while and then, okay, let me go back to being a sideman. I can't afford to be a leader. Of late, the last few years I've been writing more and experimenting with some projects, most of which have been either difficult or impossible to sell or to distribute publicly. At this time I think that's something that I want to get back to, or maybe it's some kind of a circle. I know in the 70s I was a sideman and loving it, especially hauling synthesizers and making weird noises with anybody who would let me do it. So that's the beginning of a journey, or maybe I should have done this point earlier but I think you get to where you get when it's time to get there. I have a lot of ideas of projects that I'd like to create or produce. I don't know what will happen to them. This is not a great time in the history of the music

with the technology and figure out how they're going to turn a profit and they're not signing things that they don't know how they can sell. And even things that they do know how to sell they're passing. But this is something that I want to do that I think has to come out of me, there's actually three or four projects that I've already started on that I'm not sure where they're going or what I'm going to do with them when I get to the other end but I'm going to do them anyway. Physically part of my plan is to — I was talking about Woodstock a while ago, but of just kind of moving up there and getting into the woods and just connecting with the art community up there, because there's a lot of opportunities to just take it easy and develop stuff. And I think it's time for me to cast off some of the pressures I've been under, just being in Manhattan and maintaining a studio and it's $450 a month to garage my car. I love New York but it's an expensive place to keep a car.

MR: Yeah, that phone better keep ringing to make that happen, right?

PL: Which is okay, it always has, there were very few periods that I can remember where I was really hurting for work. And in honesty I think I'm very fortunate but for the most part I've never gone looking for work, it's been word of mouth and the phone usually rings. It's good. I am very fortunate. And I'm still doing stuff now, but looking back I think I've spent a lot of time doing things that — okay I really did that one for the money. Somebody was asking me about something just this weekend. I was sitting at a bar and this guy says, "I remember this project that you did, you remember that thing we did—" and I didn't remember what it was. And I mean I remembered doing it but I didn't remember anything about it. And why this guy remembered.

MR: Well it made a big impression on him but not on you I guess.

PL: Well it's a job. And I enjoyed it while I was doing it. It distracts from things that you might like to do. And I've worked with several people over the years that I really think of as pure artists. Gil Evans is one, Gerry Mulligan, people who just — I'm going to do this, this is what I do. Gil was constantly turning down offers for professorships. He just said no, I don't want to do that, I've got a gig Monday night playing at Sweet Basil's. I can't be up in Massachusetts. So that's it. Nice to strive for that. I can't do that. I can't be a pure artist. I learned that a long time ago. But it's a thing to admire and it's a nice thing to at least model part of your life after.

MR: Well I wish you the best of luck in maybe arriving in Woodstock, and with wherever those future projects take you. It's been fascinating talking to you. I think we could probably do another one down the road and see where you go. All right?

PL: I could do one just on Gil Evans.

MR: Yes. Well we probably should do that.

MR: Right. All right. Thanks for your time today.

PL: Thank you, Monk, it was great.